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Outplayed, outplanned, outrun

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In the last 24 months, if there is one segment of Indian football that has kept the embers of the national game alive, it has been the women's team.

Having secured qualification for the AFC Women's Asian Cup across senior and age-group categories — including a first senior qualification on merit — women's football in India appeared to have found its voice.

At the AFC Women's Asian Cup 2026, a historic qualification for the FIFA World Cup was on the cards, until those hopes came crashing down. Three group-stage defeats, 16 goals conceded, and an early exit ensured that India's promising qualification run was ultimately overshadowed by a forgettable campaign.

This wasn't just a setback on the field; it was a reflection of deeper issues within the Indian football ecosystem — a fractured domestic structure, delayed appointments, and poor management by the All India Football Federation (AIFF).

The Blue Tigresses secured qualification on July 5, following which the AIFF promised a revised competition calendar, with the Indian Women's League (IWL) set to begin earlier than usual, in September instead of October.

"The earlier-than-usual scheduling would allow for ample preparation

time in the lead-up to the AFC Women's Asian Cup, scheduled for March 1-21, 2026," the AIFF said in a statement.

In reality, the IWL began only in December and, contrary to initial plans, the India U-20 team, also set to feature in the Asian Cup, did not participate.

The statement further added — "In addition, the Blue Tigresses will undergo 83 days of preparation camps, conducted in three phases. This will include 10-12 international friendlies and five to seven matches with domestic teams." However, India ended up playing only three international friendlies.

A planned tour of North Macedonia fell through due to visa issues, and while the federation may not have had complete control over it, the absence of a contingency plan was telling.

The team's next fixtures came against Japan, Vietnam, and Chinese Taipei — all of whom have previously featured in the FIFA World Cup.

Football is not just about the noise from the sidelines on matchdays. It is built on quieter, meticulous preparation that precedes them. That crucial groundwork seemed lacking.

The appointment of head coach Amelia Valverde further highlighted the timing issues. A World Cup-tested tactician from Costa Rica, Valverde arrived with a rich resume, having managed her national team at two World Cups.

However, a side shaped over 48 weeks under Crispin Chhetri had just six weeks to adapt to a new coach and system ahead of a major tournament.

The contrast with other teams was stark. Japan appointed Nils Nielsen in December 2024, while Vietnam's Mai Duc Chung has been with the squad in various capacities for over a decade, providing continuity and stability — the lack of which was reflected in India's results. A 1-2 defeat to Vietnam was followed by an 11-0 demolition at the hands of Japan. In the third game, Chinese Taipei won 3-1 against India.

Off the field, matters were no less concerning. Days before the tournament, the Indian team received ill-fitting jerseys, with a majority of players reportedly uncomfortable in the kits. Even though replacements were arranged in a hurry, the dented morale of the team due to this episode was palpable.

If that was not enough, injuries compounded the challenge. Attacking midfielder Anju Tamang was ruled out before the tournament, while captain Sweetie Devi — arguably India's best defender — played all matches with heavily taped knees.

India began the tournament in a 4-4-2 formation, deviating from Valverde's preferred 3-4-3, yet the flanks remained completely exposed. Against Vietnam, all three of the opposition's goals, including a